At the peak of their power in the 1930s, estimates suggest that the Chettiars had 1650 firms in Burma, 1000 each in Malaysia and Singapore, 500 in Sri Lanka, 200 in French Indo-China (Vietnam, Laos and Cambodia) and 150 in other East Asian regions.[20] The Great Depression was the first shock that knocked the wind out of these sails. The collapse in world trade affected the peasants' ability to repay debts and, overnight, the Chettiars became owners of large tracts of land that they held as collateral. In lower Burma, they came to occupy a quarter of the rice-cropped area.[21] In the past, the Chettiars would sell the land back when trading conditions improved, but the Great Depression was far more intense than previous crises. Nationalist outpourings against them in Burma and the Japanese invasion of South East Asia sealed the deal for the Chettiars, who returned home empty-handed.

The big Chettiar groups—Rajah Sir Muthiah, M.A. Chidambaram, M.Ct. Muthiah, A.M.M., Karumuthu, Somasundaram—turned inwards and started investing in sectors beyond banking such as cotton textiles, fertilizers and engineering goods. Most Chettiars turned towards government jobs and other occupations. The heyday of the Chettiar financial empire is over. What remains in Chettinad are the grand mansions built using Burmese teak, and an occasional reminder to the Burmese government about their past migration and business. In 2007, the Chettiar-run Burma Investors Group was formed to stake claim on assets worth over Rs 1 lakh crore remaining in Burma.[22] If that ever materializes, there will undoubtedly be celebrations in Chettinad, that too with a lot of kavuni arisi.

Punjabi Wanderlust

Bollywood cinema routinely takes its audience to lands they cannot visit, mountains they cannot climb and lavish weddings they can never afford. Escapist cinema requires imagination, but above all it requires capital and experience. Bollywood's escapist ideals have been influenced by the Punjabis, especially those belonging to business communities that enjoy an extraordinary migration history.